

CAD FORUM

ASSESSING ARGUMENTATION IN THE 2000 POLITICAL CAMPAIGNS

Brian R. McGee, Editor

The 2000 political campaign provided communication scholars with an intriguing opportunity to examine the evolution of campaign practice and political argument in the United States. Beyond the high drama of the Florida vote recount and the litigation inspired by recount efforts, local and statewide political campaigns generated a fascinating array of arguments designed to convince citizens—or, at least, undecided and likely voters—of the merits of voting for or against specific candidates or issues. For decades students of communication have studied recently completed political campaigns in order to evaluate the state of political discourse and to ask how that discourse might be improved. This forum continues that tradition.

Those familiar with *Contemporary Argumentation and Debate* know that the lion's share of space in each issue of the journal usually is devoted to the theory and practice of academic debate. However, an examination of the 2000 political campaign season gives us another opportunity to demonstrate that, as a community, we are not only interested in a narrowly defined debate pedagogy. In this forum the authors of these five essays examine the argumentation practices of political candidates, journalists, and campaign organizations. In so doing, they demonstrate that those of us who study argumentation can and should make a contribution to the ongoing conversation about the quality of political deliberation in the United States.

The essays that appear here are diverse in terms of thesis and subject matter, though they are united by their interest in the practice of public argument, however defined. Happily, the contributions of these essays to our discipline are as insightful as they are varied. **Jerry L. Miller** and **Raymie E. McKerrow** assess the relationship between reason and emotion in their analysis of the Bush-Gore presidential debates. **Debian Marty** explores the harmful implications of competitive argumentation practices in the aftermath of the post-presidential election debacle in Florida. **Carrie Crenshaw** reminds us that the detritus of the presidential campaign should not preclude analysis of other recent political campaigns in her treatment of race and argument theory and practice in two Alabama Supreme Court campaigns. **Valerie A. Sulfaro**, a political scientist, examines the arguments in presidential campaign advertisements in light of ongoing research in political psychology. Finally,

David E. Williams provides a practical, first-person commentary on the DebateWatch program, which has involved many scholars in the intercollegiate debate community since its inception. Read together, these essays are a thought-provoking, important, and timely treatment of the ways in which argumentation theory and practice are intertwined with our methods for selecting political leaders in the United States, and they hint at intriguing possibilities for both reconsidering argumentation pedagogy and reforming campaign practice.

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